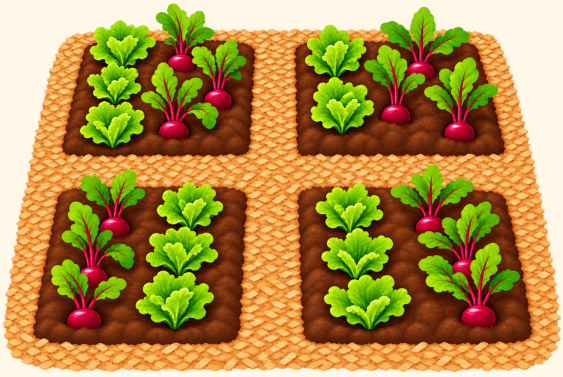
Beds and paths that work for you

Beds and paths can take several shapes. The useful question is whether you can reach the crops and move around comfortably. These three arrangements can work with digging or no-dig.



Straight paths connect across the plot.

Conventional paths

Straight paths divide the plot into rectangular beds. They make a straightforward route for carrying tools or pushing a barrow, and regular beds are convenient to cover with nets. Cross-paths save a long walk round, but use growing space. Keep them where they earn their keep, and make each bed narrow enough to tend from its edges.



A short path opens into a working space.

Keyhole beds

A short entrance opens into a standing space, with the bed wrapped around it. You can reach into the bed from this pocket as well as the outer edge, saving a path across the whole bed. It is useful where space is tight, but curved edges and the narrow entrance need careful setting out. Check your reach before planting.

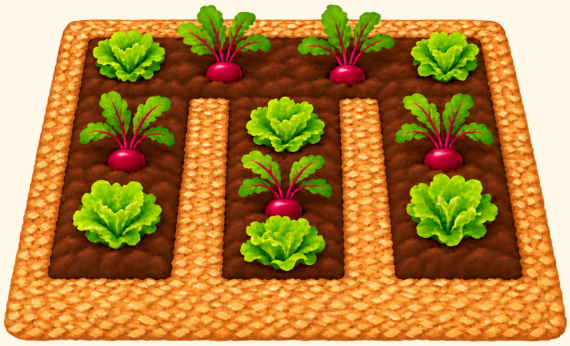
Keep the middle within reach

About 4 ft is a useful starting width for a bed reached from both sides, but your arms decide the final measurement. Make a bed against a wall narrower. You should be able to sow, weed and harvest every part without standing on the growing soil.

John: Raised Beds. RHS: raised beds. Garden Organic: Making Full Use of Space.

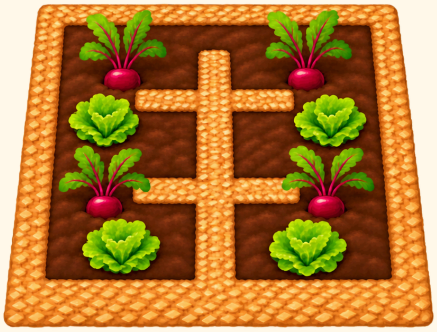
Beds and paths continued

Borrowing from nature



Finger paths enter from one side.

Finger paths are short paths that stop before the far edge, making a shape like the fingers in a hand. You gain extra growing space this way, but lose access from one edge.



A leaf pattern branches from a central path.

A plant leaf maximises photosynthesis area with veins spreading out from a central spine. You can mimic this pattern with your paths, to maximise your growing area.

Give the paths a shape that suits the ground, then try it out with pegs and string. A clever drawing is only useful if you can work from it.

Work with sun and slope

Where the site allows, run long beds north to south so tall crops share their shade across the day. Existing buildings and drainage may matter more than compass neatness. Watch where rain collects before settling the layout.

Try the paths for size

Peg out the edges, then walk the routes with a loaded barrow. Allow room to park, turn and work beside it. Check with everyone who will use the plot; a path that suits you may be awkward for somebody else.

Sides are optional

Mounded beds need no timber and leave fewer crevices for slugs in a wet garden. Framed beds hold a flatter surface and can raise the working height. Choose what makes the plot easier to use, then prepare the ground using the Cultivation pages.

John: Raised Beds; Sun, Drainage & Access, 00:03–05:37. Layout ideas, not scale plans.